

Enabling Indian languages on the FOSS desktop

Part 2

The Little GNOME Stands Tall



The smirking little leprechaun—stands up to KDE, doesn't he, the spunky dwarf? As we will see, it takes a little more configuration than KDE, but GNOME users, too, can type on their desktops in their mother tongues. The nerve of the GNOME!

KDE users, beware. We're fast losing sniggering rights—if we ever had them—to GNOME.

The dumb user's desktop environment, as we called it, stole a march on us with Orca, the blind-friendly screen-reader. Now, the SCIM application on GNOME is threatening to do so on the Indian-language front, particularly in the case of the Devanagari script—I can personally attest that it includes the additional letters that the Marathi script uses, which is an indicator. Now SCIM does have stability issues on some distributions, but the remedy is only a matter of time, and it's stable on the major distros—besides being as easy to use as KDE's keyboard tool. Where the GNOME application lags behind is that it requires the download of fonts and code before it can use Indian languages. Unlike most KDE distros, it isn't ready out-of-the-box. But this is easily solved.

Downloading fonts

The process of downloading and installing Indian language fonts, indeed any fonts, differs from distribution to distribution. Mandriva does this from the Mandriva Control

Centre, and, in Ubuntu 8.10, which we've used for this article, this is as easily accomplished from the top panel menu thus: *System→Administration→Language Support*.

In the *Language Support* window that now appears, make your selection. Ubuntu should download the fonts and other files required. This can take a while, but the language support application shows you the download progress.

Setting up SCIM

Next, as explained in the earlier article, you have to change your keyboard layout—the map of relationships between your keyboard keys and the alphabet. Use an application called the keyboard layout changer. The changer has a fancy name in GNOME: the Smart Common Input Method platform. You open it thus: *System→Preferences→SCIM Input Method Setup*.

The SCIM window should display a main panel with its name, and a side panel (Figure 1). This is where you will configure SCIM. From its side-panel, select *IMEngine→Global Setup*—which shows you a list of input methods in the main window (Figure 2). Select the method, or